approach, developed since World War II,[20] in which intervention to prevent genocide is actually mandatory under international law.

When we have a situation of violence against a particular ethnic and religious group that is becoming slowly normalised, combined with a failure by the international community to intervene on behalf of that group, genocide becomes increasingly likely. This trajectory can be usefully explored in the contexts of four different genocides that have scarred the twentieth century. Each had their own logic, but in each we can see the same pattern of normalising violence, the importance of a trigger event, and international silence (or inability to interfere). For our purposes, we can look at the Ottoman massacres of the Armenians in 1915–16, the Soviet crimes against the Muslim minority groups in Ukraine and Southern Russia in 1941–3, the Nazi-led holocaust against the Jews from 1933–45, and the genocide in Rwanda in 1994–5.

The normalisation of violence

In the case of the Armenian massacres of 1915–16, a new Ottoman regime, established by the Young Turks in 1908, had turned against the multi-cultural norms of the old monarchy and had started to stress the 'threat' posed by various non-Turkish groups (Slavs in southeastern Europe, Arabs and Armenians) to the Turkish people. Up to the final years of the Ottoman Empire, the regime was multi-cultural and usually broadly tolerant of the various ethnic groups within its borders. There were periods of active repression, but state violence against identifiable ethnic or religious groups was usually connected to wars or external threats, as for example were the massacres in the Balkans in 1877–8[21] and 1912–13,[22] when there were major revolts against Ottoman rule, combined with wars with external powers who backed those ethnic groups.

As such, there was no systemic denigration of the Armenians for most of the Ottoman Empire era. After the Young Turk Revolution in 1908[23] the new regime took a stance that was more aggressively Turkish in its identity, and also, by 1914, it had lost most of its Balkan provinces in the 1912–13 war. The advent of World War I brought nationalist revolts by the Arabs in the south and, to a lesser extent, by the Armenians in the north-east. Turkey's entry into World War I also brought it into conflict with Tsarist